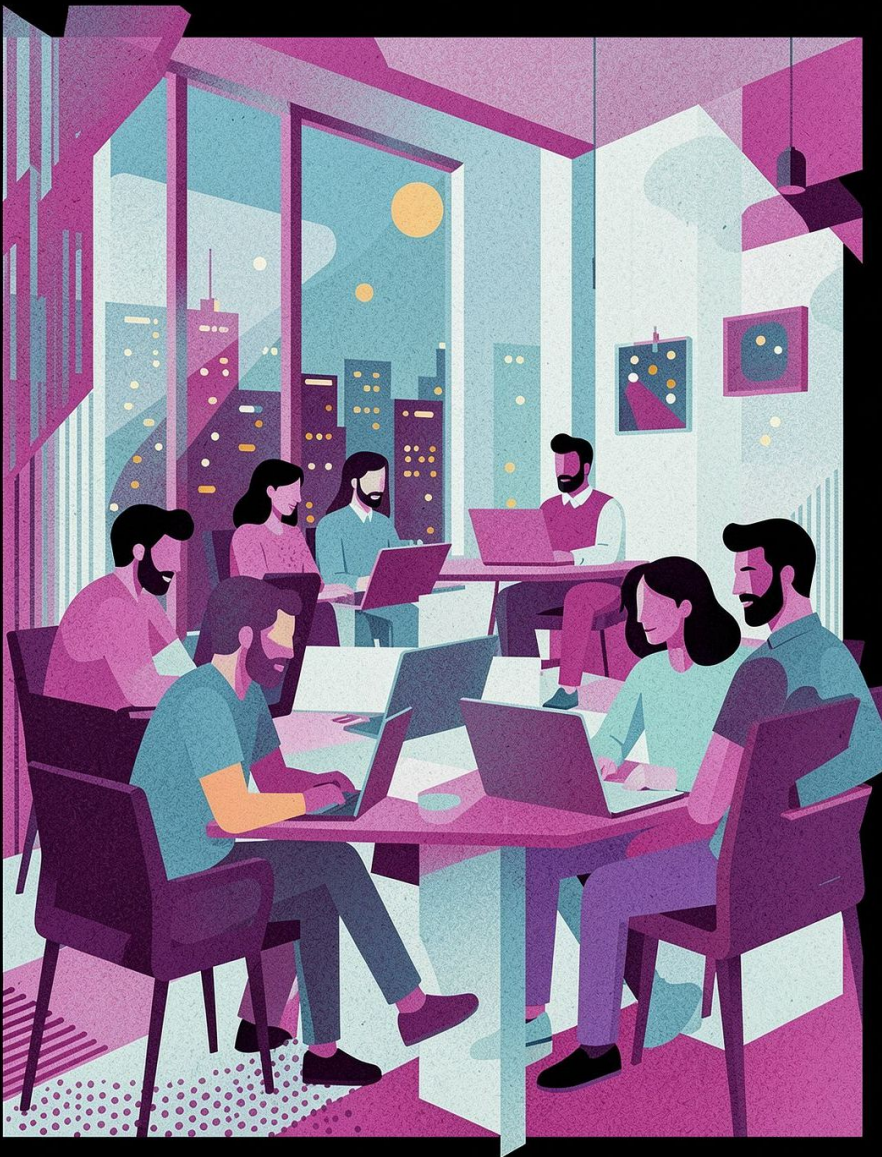
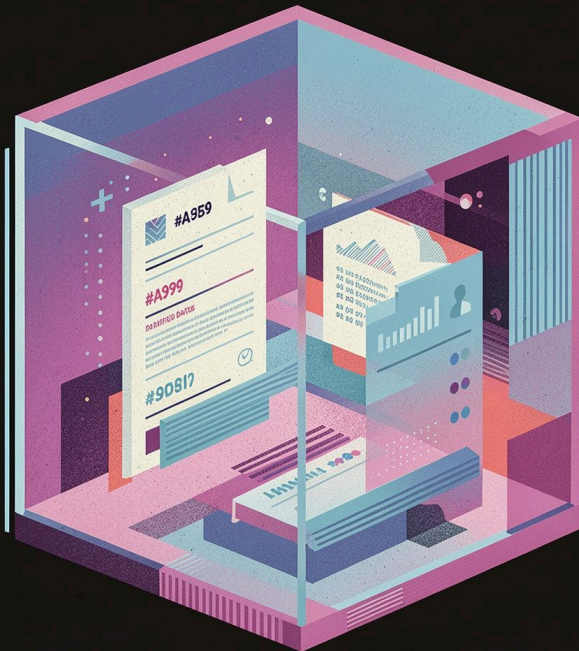




The Hidden Economy: 1,000 Startups Reveal How Founders Actually Make Money

A deep dive into TrustMRR — the verified dataset cutting through startup hype to expose what founders *really* earn.

What is TrustMRR? The Startup Transparency Revolution



→ MRR = Monthly Recurring Revenue

The **real money** startups make each month — not projections, not pitch deck promises.

→ Verified, Audited Financial Data

A database of **1,000+ startups** with transparent, audited revenue figures.

→ The Anti-Hype Source

Unlike glossy pitch decks, TrustMRR shows what founders *actually* earn.

The Brutal Truth: 68% of Startups Make Less Than \$1,000/Month

Most founders are not building unicorns — they're building sustainable side projects. The revenue reality is far quieter than Silicon Valley headlines suggest.

68%

Under \$1K/mo

The vast majority

17%

\$1K–\$10K/mo

Early traction

10%

\$10K–\$100K/mo

Scaling stage

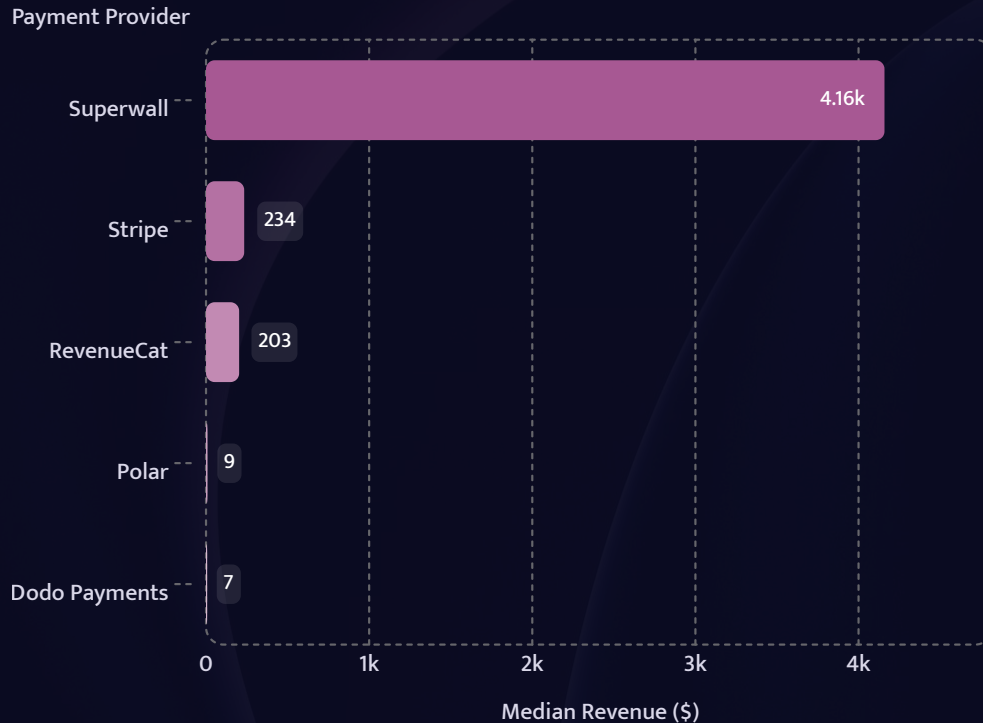
5%

\$100K+/mo

The outliers



The Payment Provider Hierarchy: Who Wins?



What the Numbers Tell Us

- **Stripe dominates** with 60% market share — the default for SaaS founders, median revenue \$234/mo
- **RevenueCat** powers mobile apps at 14% share, median \$203/mo — app monetization is real
- **Superwall** is the dark horse: smallest user base, but highest median at \$4,159/mo — premium positioning works
- **Polar & Dodo** are emerging challengers still finding their footing



Geography Matters: Where Startups Thrive

United States

Dominant hub — highest concentration of revenue-generating startups and the deepest ecosystem support.

Europe (DE, GB, FR)

Strong secondary hubs with mature SaaS cultures and growing B2B markets.

Emerging (IN, BR, AR)

Fast-growing presence in the dataset — lower average revenue today, but trajectory is upward.

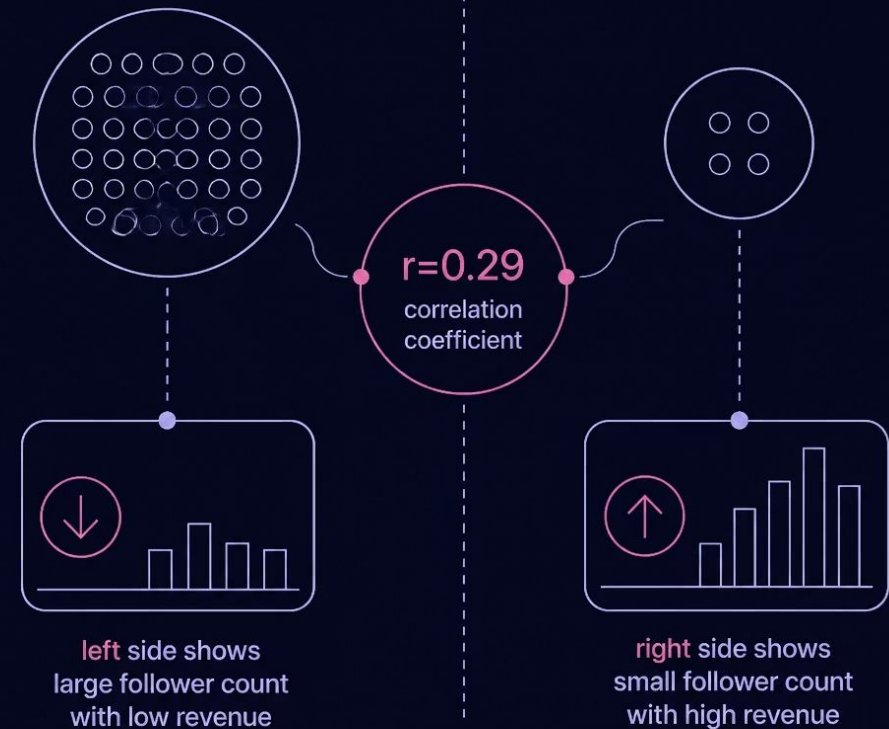
The Follower Paradox: Why Your Twitter Audience Doesn't Equal Revenue

The data delivers a humbling verdict for social-media-first founders.

- Correlation between X (Twitter) followers and revenue is **weak: $r = 0.29$**
- **80% of startups** grew revenue faster than their audience
- Followers are a vanity metric — paying customers are the only metric that matters

📌 **The lesson:** Build product first. Audience follows — not the reverse.

Weak correlation
between social media
followers and revenue:

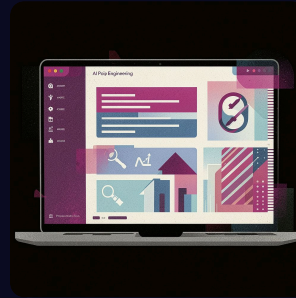


The Outliers: Who's Actually Winning?



Speak Silq

3,458 followers — AI-powered education tools with a loyal, engaged niche audience driving consistent revenue.



Prompt Builder

2,977 followers — AI productivity tools solving a real workflow pain point for developers and marketers.



Summarywise

2,008 followers — Content summarization for the attention-scarce internet. Simple problem, sticky product.



The pattern: AI tools + an engaged (not just large) audience = sustainable, defensible revenue.



The Stealth Company Phenomenon: 1 in 5 Startups Hide Their Identity

Multiple "**Stealth Company**" entries in the dataset reveal a deliberate founder strategy hiding in plain sight.

The Strategy

Launch quietly, validate product-market fit, *then* go public. Zero PR pressure, pure focus.

The Risk

No audience means harder distribution at scale — but less noise and distraction in the critical early stage.

Payment Provider Reveals Business Model: SaaS vs. Mobile Apps

Stripe

SaaS/B2B leader with top market share; best for subscriptions.

Superwall

Premium positioning; smallest base but highest median revenue at \$4,159.



RevenueCat

Mobile app focus; proven app monetization and strong revenue rank.

Your choice of payment infrastructure isn't just operational — it signals your entire business model. Stripe founders are building subscription SaaS; RevenueCat founders are betting on mobile; Superwall founders are going premium-first. Each path has a distinct revenue ceiling and growth trajectory baked in from day one.

The Real Lesson: Consistency Beats Virality



Zero followers, real revenue

Startups with no social presence still generate consistent monthly revenue — product quality is the moat.



Solve real problems

Sustainable growth comes from addressing genuine pain points, not chasing algorithmic trends or viral moments.



Boring is profitable

The 1,000 startups in this dataset prove it: unglamorous, useful businesses quietly win every time.



Your Takeaway: The Startup Ecosystem is Bigger Than You Think

TrustMRR's 1,000 verified startups expose a thriving hidden economy most people never see.



Flying Under the Radar

1,000+ startups generating real revenue with no press, no hype, no VC spotlight.



Redefine Success

It's not about being the next unicorn. It's about building something **people actually pay for**.



The Winning Formula

Patience + product focus + the right payment infrastructure = a **sustainable, profitable business**.

The data doesn't lie: the most successful founders in this dataset aren't the loudest — they're the most consistent.